

From Captive to Creator: The Unlikely Story of Architect William Sprat

History is full of unexpected turnarounds, but few match the dramatic life of William Sprat (often spelled **Sprats** or **Spratts**). He arrived on American soil as a British soldier sworn to crush a rebellion. Yet, he spent the rest of his life crafting the very physical landscape of the young United States. As an architect and master joiner, Sprat introduced a level of formal British sophistication that forever changed post-Revolutionary New England architecture.

Here is the remarkable, verified biography of Connecticut's legendary prisoner-turned-builder.

From Redcoat to Prisoner of War

William Sprat was born on January 27, 1757, in Auchlyne, Perthshire, Scotland. As a young man, he joined the British Standing Army, serving as an artillery matross (a soldier who assisted the gunners) under General John Burgoyne.

In 1777, Sprat marched south from Quebec into New York, caught up in a campaign meant to split the American colonies in two. Instead, Burgoyne's forces met a devastating defeat at the **Battle of Saratoga**. Swept up in the surrender, Sprat was taken as a prisoner of war.

The American forces marched British captives eastward, and Sprat found himself incarcerated in Connecticut, moving between gaols (jails) in Hartford and Farmington. Known among guards for his clever, daring escape attempts, he remained a captive until he was officially paroled in September 1780. Having sworn an oath never again to bear arms against the colonies, Sprat chose not to board a ship back to Europe. He chose to stay.

Rebuilding a New Nation

Before the war, American domestic architecture was largely defined by colonial austerity—plain, deeply functional, and restrained. Sprat, deeply educated in the grand, formal English Georgian architectural traditions, offered something entirely fresh to a wealthy class of merchants eager to display their new post-war status.

He quickly established a reputation as a masterful designer and joiner. Local lore suggests that Sprat even hired fellow former prisoners—specifically Hessian soldiers skilled in carpentry—to help execute his grand visions.

His Masterpieces and Enduring Legacy:

- **Old Gate Mansion (Farmington, CT):** Built circa 1782 for merchant Zenas Cowles, this is perhaps his most famous residential work. Sprat built a grand, seven-bay Georgian mansion right over an existing 1690 structure. It features corner quoins crafted from wood to look like stone, a dramatic central Palladian window, and a Chinese Chippendale style front gate that gives the estate its name.
- **The Linden (Litchfield, CT):** Designed for the successful merchant Julius Deming, this majestic estate leaned into post-revolutionary elegance. The home was so widely admired that it launched a trend across the region, prompting other elites to commission similar grand properties.
- **The Henry Champion House (Colchester, CT):** Built around 1790 for the son of Revolutionary War veteran Col. Henry Champion, this home stands today on the National Register of Historic Places, lauded for its intricate vertical-grain pine paneling and unique entry sequences.
- **Civic Infrastructure:** Beyond private homes, Sprat's hands shaped public life. He designed the **Litchfield County Courthouse** in 1797 (which unfortunately burned down in 1886) and the **Town Meeting House** in Georgia, Vermont.

Personal Life and Final Years

Sprat fully integrated into the fabric of New England life. By 1782, he married Elizabeth Seelye, the daughter of a prominent Litchfield justice. Together, they raised a large family while Sprat ran a highly successful architectural practice.

Following Elizabeth's passing in 1800, Sprat eventually relocated to Whitehall, New York. He lived there until his death on June 24, 1810, at the age of 53. He was laid to rest just across the state line in Carver Falls Cemetery in Rutland, Vermont, beside his first wife.

Today, William Sprat's story remains a captivating testament to how the bitter divides of war can give way to the enduring beauty of art and community creation.

Verified Sources

1. **National Register of Historic Places:** Architectural survey records detailing his work on the Henry Champion House and surrounding Litchfield County master joiners.
2. **Public Art CT / Connecticut Digital Archive:** Documented biographical outlines tracking his journey from Auchlyne to Connecticut.

3. **The Farmington Historical Society:** Records on the local history of prisoners turned builders following the Battle of Saratoga.
4. **Historic Buildings of Connecticut:** Architectural analysis and photography tracking the evolution of the Old Gate Mansion.
5. **Old Time New England Bulletin:** Landmark essays by architectural historian William Lamson Warren, including '*William Sprats, Master Joiner - Connecticut's Federalist Architect*'.